```
user = {}
user?.contact?.phone?.home = '555 5555'
```

That's a *bad* idea. What's the result of the assignment? Is the value of `user.contact .phone.home` now `5`? No. The `null` was soaked immediately and `user` doesn't even have a `contact` property:

```
user.contact?
# false
```

Don't use null soak for property assignment. Only use it for *safe access*. Conditional assignment, on the other hand, can be useful and safe for local variables.

7.3.2. Conditional assignment

Suppose you want to assign a value to a variable only if it does *not* already contain a value. A simple way to do that is by combining the existential operator with assignment:

```
phone = undefined
phone ?= '555 5555'
phone
# '555 5555'

phone = null
phone ?= '555 1111'
phone
# '555 1111'

phone ?= 'something else'
phone
# '555 1111'
```

Be careful, though; existential assignment isn't for variables that haven't been defined:

```
variableYouNeverDeclared ?= 'something'
# error: the variable "variableYouNeverDeclared" can't be assigned
with ?= because it has not been declared before
```